

IN CONTEXT

The lure of Paris

Rossini had earned enough from Paris to retire in his thirties; Donizetti also hoped for early retirement. His nine years in the capital from 1838 met with success and setbacks. Although he spent six months each year in Vienna, serving the Hapsburg emperor as court composer, life in Paris did not run so smoothly. Soon after his comic opera *Don Pasquale* triumphed at the Théâtre Italien, Donizetti succumbed to the syphilis he had contracted as a student. His physical and mental decline, and fondness for threesomes with prostitutes, fed the Paris gossip mill. Donizetti spent his final months in Bergamo waiting for death in a specially adapted wing chair.



THEATRE ITALIEN, PARIS, WHERE DONIZETTI'S
DON PASQUALE PREMIERED IN 1843

Extreme poverty shaped Gaetano Donizetti's early childhood. Born in Bergamo in September 1797, the fifth of six children, he was raised in the dismal basement of an apartment block. In 1806, the family's